DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

One Person, the Whole World: How Do Our Actions Move Creation?

Daat Tevunot §121-124

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** End of the Summary of Section 5, then §121-124 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 24 April 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Finishing the summary of Section 5

The class completed the short summary of Section 5 (page 657). Evil is a new phenomenon, created to test man and give him reward, temporary and within limits. God does not create evil through a direct emanation, since He is wholly good. He creates it indirectly: first He sent an emanation that would give rise to good, then He held back parts of it, "that's the dial analogy", damaging its arrangement. In a later stage He created actual beings into the evil that already existed.

Before bringing the world into being, God prepared everything in potential. By holding back His emanation, evil came to exist at that level. Then He turned back towards creation and shone His light again, so that the world of good and evil could survive for its set time, while He guides it to the point when evil will be destroyed.

The last paragraph of the summary, still to be learned inside, says that all creation is one complex interconnected system whose purpose is for man to serve God, and that evil, built into this system, becomes a vehicle for good in three ways: from its darkness we will recognise God's light; by overcoming its tests we gain merit; and it gives us the task of perfecting the world, making us God's partners.

Two directions of influence

The Rabbi recalled Derech Hashem. There are two systems. One is from above to below: the existence of this table, of all creatures, comes down from above. The other is from below to above, through human actions and free will. They are interconnected: you do something good, it rises, and then comes back down.

§121-124: man moves everything

Section 5, part 3 begins on page 280. Having explained how evil exists, the Sekhel now explains how man relates to it, starting with an introduction.

Hashem created many creatures in a hierarchy, each needed in its place, "even the little insect". But all of it stands on one foundation: that we rectify all the deficiencies in existence, and so rise level after level until, at the end of days, we cleave to the Almighty. Good attaches to good.

Then the key principle: Hashem wanted all of existence to be moved by the actions of man. The Rabbi gave the Ramhal's image of a clock with interlocking cogs, where one small movement moves many others. In a clock, he said, the hour hand seems most important, but it is moved by the minutes, which are moved by the seconds. Man is the seconds. "Everything moves from it."

We see only the physical side of our actions. When I lift something, you see it shake. You do not see the spiritual effects on all the other cogs of existence. But there are many deep things here: man can raise holiness in the world or bring it down, and this is only because he has a soul, and therefore choice. This is why King David says in Tehillim, "Many are the things You have done, Your wonders and Your thoughts towards us", and "I am awesomely and wonderfully made... and my soul knows it well": the responsibility given to man is astounding. The body cannot sense this; only the soul does.

Two categories of time

On page 284 the Ramhal narrows in: one aspect of man's influence is his effect on evil, and all of it depends on the unity, the revelation of God's oneness. God's final goal is that His oneness be revealed, as the verses say, "you will know that I am Hashem".

Once that happens, all that remains is to enjoy and cleave to Him, understanding more and more. The Rabbi stressed that growth never stops, even after 10,000. The Gemara at the end of Berakhot says that talmidei hakhamim have no rest, not in this world and not in the world to come; they go "from strength to strength". The more you connect, the more you understand, and the more you understand, the more you connect. "It's not a vicious cycle, it's a fantastic cycle." Since God is infinite, the growth is infinite.

So God's actions divide into two categories:

1. What will be after His oneness is revealed: the reward. We cannot know its details now. Hazal's "crowns on their heads" are not physical; they mean intellectual grasp. In this world there are thousands of sensual pleasures; there, there is one pleasure, haskalah, the pleasure of the intellect and connection, with countless levels within it.
2. What God does while the truth is not yet revealed: from the beginning of existence until the final redemption, of which Zekharyah says, "On that day Hashem will be one." The Rabbi noted that this is why we end our prayers with this verse, and that some communities continue with Shema Yisrael, which expresses the same idea.

The whole system of cogs and man's influence belongs to the second category, the time of concealment.

Evil as a cog

Now evil enters. In itself, evil is destruction. But as one of the cogs in the system, it actually benefits man, because all of his merit and the completion of his work depend on it, through its

being overcome. It exists only to be chipped away, like the stone at the crossroads in the Midrash.

Viewed alone, evil is purely bad. Seen as part of the whole interconnected mechanism, it has a role to play and leads to the perfection of each person, if he makes the right choices. If not, it pushes the other cogs the wrong way and the ripple effect goes downward.

Evil has two periods: the time of its existence, now, and the time of its destruction. A participant said it will be good in the end. The Rabbi went further: it is good now, though we will only see how at the end.

A dangerous idea

The Ramhal then says that even when evil grows stronger, there is benefit in it: from the depth of the darkness, the greatness of the light will be recognised. The Rabbi warned that this idea has been dangerously abused. The followers of Shabtai Sevi, the false messiah who converted to Islam, justified terrible sins by claiming that the Mashiah needed them to descend into the depths of darkness so that the light could come out. He promised to discuss this properly next time.

Summary

- Evil came about through withdrawal, then actual beings were created into it; God's light then sustains the world for its set time.
- All creation is an interconnected system, like the cogs of a clock, and man is the cog that moves everything.
- Man's power to raise or lower the world comes from his soul and his free choice.
- After the revelation, reward is endless intellectual closeness to God; before it, we live in the time of concealment, where this system operates.
- Evil is destructive in itself, but as part of the system it serves good; the idea that darkness brings greater light must never be used to justify sin.

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